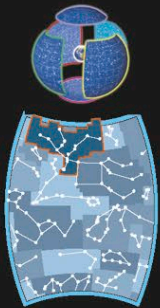


ANDROMEDA

Andromeda



SIZE RANKING 19

BRIGHTEST STARS

Alpheratz (α) 2.1,
Mirach (β) 2.1

GENITIVE

Andromedae

ABBREVIATION And

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.

October–November

FULLY VISIBLE

90°N–37°S



This celebrated constellation of the northern skies depicts the daughter of the mythical Queen Cassiopeia, who is represented by a neighboring constellation. The head of the princess is marked by Alpheratz—Alpha (α) Andromedae—which is the star at the nearest corner of the Square of Pegasus, in another adjacent constellation. Long ago, Alpheratz was regarded as being shared with

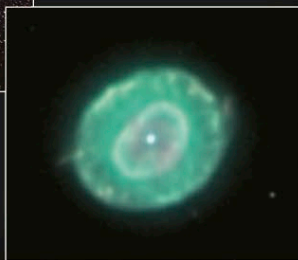


THE ANDROMEDA GALAXY

Only the inner parts of M31 are bright enough to be seen with small instruments. CCD images such as this bring out the full extent of the spiral arms. Below M31 on this image lies M110, while M32 is on its upper rim.

THE BLUE SNOWBALL

When seen through a small telescope, NGC 7662 appears as a bluish disk. Its structure is brought out only on CCD images such as this one.



the constellation Pegasus, where it marked the navel of the horse. The star's official name—Alpheratz—is derived from an Arabic term that means “the horse’s navel.”

SPECIFIC FEATURES

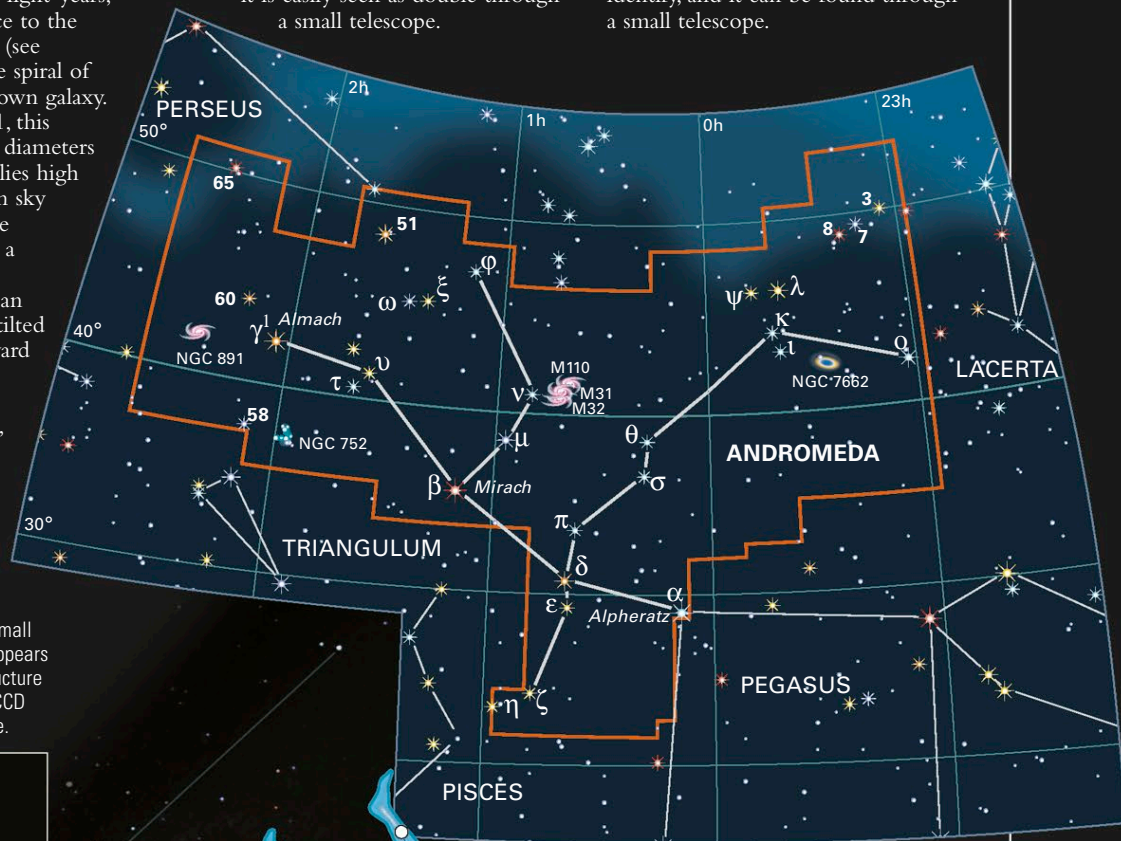
On a clear night, the farthest it is possible to see with the naked eye is about 2.5 million light-years, which is the distance to the Andromeda Galaxy (see pp.312–313), a huge spiral of stars similar to our own galaxy. Also known as M31, this galaxy spans several diameters of a full moon and lies high in the mid-northern sky on fall evenings. The naked eye sees it as a faint patch; it looks elongated, rather than spiral, because it is tilted at a steep angle toward the Earth. When looking at M31 through a telescope, low magnification must be used to give the widest field of view

and to concentrate the light. The small companion galaxies, M32 and M110, are difficult to see through a small telescope.

Gamma (γ) Andromedae, known also as Almach (see p.277), is a double star of contrasting colors. It consists of an orange giant star of magnitude 2.3 and a fainter blue companion, and it is easily seen as double through a small telescope.

The open star cluster NGC 752 spreads over an area larger than a full moon and can be identified with binoculars, but a small telescope is needed to resolve its individual stars of 9th magnitude and fainter.

NGC 7662, which is popularly known as the Blue Snowball, is one of the easiest planetary nebulae to identify, and it can be found through a small telescope.



ANDROMEDA

MYTHS AND STORIES

HEROIC RESCUE

According to Greek mythology, Andromeda was chained to a rock on the seashore and offered as a sacrifice to a sea monster in atonement for the boastfulness of her mother, Queen Cassiopeia. The Greek hero Perseus, flying home after slaying Medusa, the Gorgon, noticed the maiden's plight. He responded by swooping down in his winged sandals and killing the sea monster. He then whisked Andromeda to safety and married her.

DAMSEL IN DISTRESS

The Flemish artist Rubens added the flying horse Pegasus to his 17th-century depiction of Andromeda's dramatic rescue by Perseus from captivity on the rock.



HEAD TO TOE

Andromeda is one of the original Greek constellations. Its brightest stars represent the princess's head (α), her pelvis (β), and her left foot (γ).